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Inside the \$32 Million Federal Solar Jobs Investment

CHAZ WILKE ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/AUTHOR/CHAZW/](https://solarmehome.com/author/chaZW/)) / JUNE 12, 2015 ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/INSIDE-THE-32-MILLION-FEDERAL-SOLAR-JOBS-INVESTMENT/](https://solarmehome.com/inside-the-32-million-federal-solar-jobs-investment/))



It is hard to understate the significance of the U.S. solar jobs market right now. This should come as welcome news to those working in the fossil fuel industry, which continues to slump. The solar jobs market is booming for good reason, with a new connection every 2.5 minutes (<http://bit.ly/1T-gMxiY>), and no sign of slowing down, solar appears poised to overtake the old guard and become the top dog in the energy industry.

On May 26, the Energy Department announced a \$32 million commitment in funding and training assistance to American workers to help strengthen the “solar energy workforce and further drive down the cost of solar by developing innovative low-cost concentrating solar power collectors and increasing access to critical solar data.”

This new funding will be overseen by the Energy Department's SunShot initiative, which rolled out (<http://bit.ly/1Sb6juA>) in early 2011 to oversee new programs and workforce training in the clean energy industry.

Where the federal funding is going

Of that \$32 million, \$12 million will go toward programs to increase diversity in the solar workforce. “That includes solar-trained and credentialed real estate professionals as well as white collar workers in the insurance, finance, and utility industries. Fire and safety professionals are also included in the new funding announcement,” reports (<http://bit.ly/1lzzKC4>) Tina Casey at *CleanTechnica*. “Projects selected under this program will also create new credentials for solar energy professionals and ensure a wide diversity of Americans continue to enter the solar workforce,” reads (<http://1.usa.gov/1IO4gLH>) the Energy Department press release.

\$5 million of the federal Energy Department funding is going toward programs that increase data collection and sharing within the solar industry. This is intended to help cut costs and increase transparency across the industry. With additional data provided by each solar manufacturer, there is a hope that it will increase innovation, drive down costs and possibly spur consumer adoption.

R&D (Research & Development) gets \$15 million of the proposed \$32 million. The goal is to drive down the enormous costs of concentrating solar power (CSP). This process of harnessing the sun’s energy is different than standard photovoltaic solar panels. With concentrated solar power, the method involves many perfectly angled mirrors laid out in an array to focus, or concentrate, sunlight to a single point. The equipment at that concentrated point would then convert the solar energy into useable electricity. The Energy Department notes that 40 percent of the total concentrated solar power system cost is attributed to the initial setup and construction of the mirror array.

Takeaway

Clean energy continues its incredible growth both at home and abroad. It is heartening to see the federal government commit to building an infrastructure that works. Research and development paired with training a competitive clean energy workforce may be the key component to make sure this movement remains stable for years to come. It appears the future for clean energy is bright, and the American government is intent on backing it up with much needed funding.

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